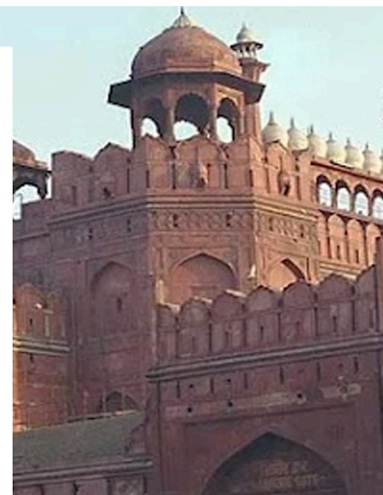
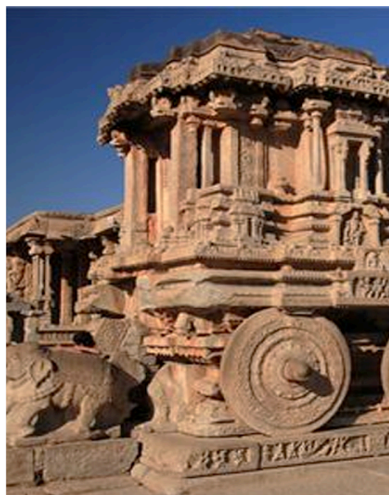


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Bhakti Movement in North India



Bhakti Movement in North India



Bhakti Movement

The **Bhakti Movement** was a **spiritual movement** that emphasized **devotion (bhakti)** and **personal connection to God**. It arose as a response to **social hierarchies** and **ritualism** in Hinduism and **promoted equality** and the rejection of **caste divisions**. The movement spread across **India**, taking different forms in **South and North India**.

Origin of the Bhakti Movement

- **Religious oppression:** The **varna system** and **rigid religious rituals** oppressed the lower castes.
- **Muslim rulers Atrocities:** Due to the destruction and desecration of idols by the Muslim rulers, people's inclination towards worshipping God without idols and temples increased.
- **Feudal Exploitation:** Religious movements expressed **resentment against feudal oppression**.

- **Rise of Vaishyas and Shudras:** **Urban artisans** demanded spiritual freedom and rejected the Varna hierarchy.
- **Influence of Islam:** The **liberal and tolerant spirit of the Sufi** saints and their strong faith in **monotheism influenced the Hindus**.
- **Advaita were no longer comprehensible:** Shankaracharya's path of knowledge and Advaita were no longer comprehensible to the common people.
- **Exploitative caste system:** Due to the exploitative caste system of the then Indian society, the message of social harmony and goodwill given by Bhakti saints influenced the people.

Two Types of Bhakti

- **Saguna Bhakti** – Devotion to a **God with form** (e.g., **Rama, Krishna**).
- **Nirguna Bhakti** – Devotion to a **formless, abstract God** without attributes.

Aspect	Saguna Bhakti	Nirguna Bhakti
Meaning	Devotion to a God with a form and attributes .	Devotion to a formless, attribute-less divine entity .
Philosophy	God is represented in physical form (e.g., Rama, Krishna) and human-like qualities .	God is beyond physical form and beyond attributes , representing the ultimate truth .
Examples of Deities	Rama, Krishna, Vishnu, Shiva.	A formless divine presence , often referred to as Brahman, Atman, or Shunya .
Saints Associated	- Tulsidas: Rama Bhakti - Surdas: Krishna Bhakti - Mirabai: Krishna Bhakti - Vallabhacharya: Krishna Bhakti	- Kabir: Advocated formless God - Guru Nanak: Nirguna Bhakti - Ravidas: Preached spiritual unity with formless divinity
Focus of Worship	Idol worship and devotion through rituals, prayers, and festivals .	Focus on meditation, inner reflection, and chanting (e.g., Zikr or Nam).

Language & Poetry	Devotional songs in local languages (e.g., bhajans, kirtans).	Abstract and mystical poetry focuses on oneness with the divine (e.g., Kabir's verses).
View of God	God is a personal being who interacts with the world and offers grace and blessings .	God is impersonal and beyond human comprehension, realized through self-purification and inner experience .
Practices	- Worship of idols or deities - Pilgrimages to temples - Festivals and rituals	- Meditation and introspection - Rejection of idolatry and rituals - Focus on personal experience with God
Social Impact	Encouraged community worship and festivals (e.g., Ramleela).	Promoted equality and rejection of social hierarchies like the caste system.
Textual Influence	Influenced epics and Puranas (e.g., Ramcharitmanas by Tulsidas).	Reflected in mystical verses (e.g., Kabir's Bijak, Adi Granth of Sikhism).
Geographical Spread	More popular in North India , especially among the Vaishnavas .	Spread across various regions, influenced by Sufism and Nathpanthi movements .
Goal of Devotion	Attaining divine grace and liberation through personal devotion .	Merging with the divine through self-realization and detachment from material life.

Important Bhakti Saints in North India

Saint	Period	Teachings & Contributions
Ramananda	1486–1533 CE	- Introduced Ram Bhakti and regarded Rama as the supreme deity. - Preached in vernacular languages. - Accepted disciples from all castes, including Kabir (Adopted by Neema, the wife of a Muslim weaver) and Ravidas (a leatherworker).
Kabir	15th Century	- Criticized idolatry, caste system, and rituals. - Advocated Nirguna Bhakti. - Compositions compiled in Bijak, Adi Granth, and Kabir Granthavali.
Guru Nanak	1469–1539 CE	- Founder of Sikhism and proponent of Nirguna Bhakti. - Emphasized equality, truth, and justice. - Denounced caste system and rituals. - Introduced Langar (community kitchen).
Tulsidas	1511–1623 CE	- Promoted Saguna Bhakti with devotion to Rama. - Composed Ramcharitmanas in Awadhi. - Founded Ramleela plays and the Sankatmochan Temple in Varanasi.
Surdas	1483–1563 CE	- Disciple of Vallabhacharya and Krishna devotee. - Famous for Sursagar, narrating Krishna's life. - Promoted Saguna Bhakti.
Ravidas	15th–16th Century	- Rejected caste-based discrimination. - Promoted spiritual unity and equality. - His poems are included in Guru Granth Sahib and Panchvani.

Mirabai	15th–16th Century	- Rajput princess who renounced her royal life for Krishna Bhakti. - Composed bhajans that challenged social norms. - Discipled by Ravidas.
Vallabhacharya	1479–1531 CE	- Founded the Pushtimarga sect (Way of Grace). - Advocated Shuddha-Dvaita (pure dualism). - Inspired poets like Surdas.
Shankaradeva	1449–1568 CE	- Founded the Ekasarana Dharma (Neo-Vaishnavism) in Assam. - Established Namghars (houses of recitation). - Contributed to Assamese literature and Borgeet music.

Teachings of Bhakti Saints

- **Personal Experience with God:** Bhakti is based on **individual connection** with the divine.
- **Universal God:** God is **formless, eternal, and beyond attributes**.
- **Social Equality:** Saints denounced the **caste system** and advocated equality.
- **Rejection of Rituals:** Saints **criticized rituals, idol worship, and priestly authority**.
- **Language of the People:** Saints composed poems in **local languages and dialects**.
- **Inspiration from Multiple Traditions:** Saints were influenced by **Vaishnavism, the Nathpanthi movement, and Sufism**.

Impact of the Bhakti Movement

1. **Social Reform:** Saints like **Kabir** and **Nanak** aimed to **restructure society along egalitarian lines**.
2. **Promotion of Regional Literature:** Bhakti saints are composed in **local languages** (e.g., **Hindi, Punjabi, Braj**), fostering the growth of regional literature.
3. **Musical Renaissance:** Saints like **Surdas** and **Mirabai** popularized **devotional songs** through **bhajans and kirtans**.
4. **Cultural Integration:** The Bhakti movement united **Hindus and Muslims** through **spiritual practices and shared ideals**.

5. **Development of Regional Languages:** Saints like **Amir Khusrau** used **local dialects** and incorporated **Persian poetic forms**.
6. **Promotion of Inclusiveness:** The movement **rejected caste barriers** and encouraged participation from people of all social backgrounds.

Similarities Among Bhakti Saints

- **Personal Experience with God:** Central to the teachings of all Bhakti saints.
- **Equality and Unity:** Advocated **equality across caste and religion**.
- **Criticism of Rituals:** Rejected **idol worship** and **priestly authority**.
- **Use of Local Languages:** Composed in **vernacular languages** to make teachings accessible.
- **Synthesis of Traditions:** Combined **elements of Vaishnavism, Sufism, and Nathpanthi** philosophy.

Key Concepts and Terminology

Term	Meaning
Bhakti	Devotion and personal connection to God.
Saguna Bhakti	Devotion to a God with attributes (e.g., Rama, Krishna).
Nirguna Bhakti	Devotion to a formless, attribute-less God.
Kirtan	Group singing of devotional songs.
Langar	Community kitchen introduced by Guru Nanak .
Silsilah	Lineage of spiritual teachers in Sufi orders .
Pushtimarga	Way of Grace; Vallabhacharya's sect focusing on Krishna Bhakti.
Namghars	Houses of recitation founded by Shankaradeva in Assam.
Ulatbansi	Cryptic sayings used by Kabir .